Macbeth

Trace the downfall

1 Five-act journey

1: prophecy and choice. 2: Duncan murdered; Macbeth crowned. 3: Banquo killed, Fleance escapes; ghost at banquet.

4: misleading assurances; Macduff's family killed. 5: Lady Macbeth dies; resistance defeats Macbeth; Malcolm restores rule.

2 Ambition → insecurity

Violence changes its purpose

A praised defender becomes a king who attacks his own people. He gains power but loses peace.

The witches tempt; Macbeth chooses. "Vaulting ambition" (1.7) shows he understands the danger.

New crimes try to protect the first crime; violence escalates.

Follow relationships

3 The marriage changes

Lady Macbeth initially directs the plot and challenges his manhood. After Duncan's murder she manages his panic.

Macbeth later excludes her from plans. Her sleepwalking reveals guilt; his power leaves him isolated.

Shared ambition → divided knowledge → loneliness.

4 Contrasts & victims

Banquo hears prophecy but warns of "instruments of darkness" (1.3). Macduff combines courage with grief.

Duncan's trust exposes betrayal; Lady Macduff and her son reveal tyranny's human cost.

Malcolm offers a different model of leadership.

Explain the drama

5 Motifs & stagecraft

Blood: bravery → murder → guilt. Sleep: rest → lost innocence. Washing cannot erase responsibility.

Asides/soliloquies expose hidden thoughts. Dramatic irony makes trust dangerous. Public banquet exposes private fear.

6 Answer the question

Extract: follow language, behaviour and shifts across the passage; explain audience effects.

Essay: argue across beginning, middle and end. Use precise evidence and analyse Shakespeare's choices.

15-mark extract; 25-mark essay includes 5 for writing accuracy.